THE BUMRAH SUPREMACY

ICC Cricketer of the Year Jasprit Bumrah broke more records than you can count in 2024. India's prayers for a genuine quickie have been answered, and he's gone one better—become the most feared pacer in the game

By Nikhil Naz



In its 93-year cricket history, there hasn't been a facet of the game that India hasn't 'bested' at some point or the other. The best batters, wicket-keepers, fielders, spinners, we've had all of them at some point in time. But there was one aberration—we never had the best fast bowler on the planet. This cricket season, that too has happened, thanks to Jasprit Jasbirsingh Bumrah. For a country that couldn't even lay claim to having a 'fast' bowler for much of its history until the arrival of Kapil Dev in the late 1970s, Bumrah's accession to the throne pretty much qualifies as a landing-on-the-moon moment. And whilst Kapil's greatness was never in doubt, the likes of Lillee, Holding, Imran and Marshall ensured that the best-of-his-generation tag eluded him.

It's not that Bumrah's career hasn't coincided with a host of other talented, skillful quicks: Cummins, Starc, Archer, Shaheen, Rabada, the list is long. But when arguably the greatest fast bowler to grace the 22 yards, Wasim Akram, gives his stamp of approval—"Jasprit is the best in the world"—the debate looks settled.

The stats back the fandom, too. No bowler in the history of Test cricket has taken as many wickets in a calendar year at a better strike rate: in 2024, Bumrah took 71 wickets at a phenomenal average of 14.92, striking every 30.1 balls. Overall, it was a year that saw Jassi help India get the better of England's 'bazball' at home; was lethal in the series win vs Bangladesh; engineered the win in Perth after India was bundled out for 150, and was by far the best cricketer on display across the five-Test Australia-India Border-Gavaskar Trophy series.

And that was just Test cricket. In a year when India won its first ICC title in 11 years, Bumrah was the undisputed star of the show. Not only did he finish with 15 wickets at a mind-boggling single-digit bowling average of 8.26, he also conceded just 4.17 runs an over—unheard-of figures in the slam-bang world of T20